8. Baggy Green

Picture the scene. Manuka Oval, in Canberra, is an old-fashioned ground, ringed with cypress, poplar, oak and elm trees planted nearly a century ago. Also used for prominent Aussie Rules matches, it is the venue for the tour's traditional one-day fixture against the Prime Minister's XI. Not quite cream tea and cucumber sandwich territory, but pretty civilized, right?

Wrong.

Willing pupils in the dark arts of mental degradation, some straight from primary school, wait to ambush an unthinking, unsuspecting England player. If their victim is as naïve as I was, on my first Ashes tour, he is an easy mark, and ridiculed as a cross between Mr Bean and the Upper Class Twit of the Year.

Older tormentors gather in small groups of twenty or so, to sledge in unison when England are in the field. They think they're big and brave, and they're certainly brutal. The abuse is crude, rude, relentless and acutely personal. It's not even leavened by humour, acidic or otherwise. International sportsmen are no one's idea of blushing innocents, but the invective is genuinely shocking.

When I first experienced it, in 2006, my first thought was that I was going to hate Ashes cricket. My second, on getting out for 4, caught behind by Tim Paine off Ben Hilfenhaus, was to long for the release of the local airport, ten minutes down the road. I didn't have time for a third thought, because the other delight of the day was upon me.